

Special on International Day of Yoga 2026

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International Day of Yoga and Its Influence on the Lifestyle of Common People in India



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Abstract

The International Day of Yoga, celebrated annually on 21 June since 2015, has emerged as a global movement promoting physical, mental, and spiritual well-being. Initiated by India and recognized by the United Nations, this celebration has significantly influenced the lifestyle of common people in India. The present paper critically examines the impact of the International Day of Yoga on the daily lives, health awareness, social behaviour, and holistic living practices of Indian citizens. The study highlights how yoga has moved from traditional spiritual practice to a mass movement embraced by people of different age groups, professions, and socio-economic backgrounds. The paper also discusses the role of educational institutions, media, governmental initiatives, and yoga organizations in spreading awareness regarding yoga and healthy living. It concludes that the International Day of Yoga has contributed positively towards preventive healthcare, stress management, discipline, and social harmony in India.

Keywords: International Day of Yoga, Lifestyle, Holistic Health, Indian Society, Wellness, Preventive Healthcare, Common People

Introduction

Yoga is one of the most valuable contributions of Indian culture to humanity. Rooted in ancient Indian philosophy, yoga aims at achieving harmony between body, mind, and soul. The term “Yoga” is derived from the Sanskrit root *Yuj*, meaning union or integration. Traditionally associated with spirituality and self-realization, yoga has now become a global symbol of holistic health and peaceful living.

Recognizing the universal importance of yoga, the Prime Minister of India, Narendra Modi proposed the idea of an International Day of Yoga before the United Nations General Assembly in 2014. Consequently, the United Nations declared 21 June as the International Day of Yoga, which has been celebrated worldwide since 2015.

In India, the celebration of International Day of Yoga has transformed yoga into a household practice. Large-scale yoga sessions, awareness campaigns, workshops, seminars, and educational activities have encouraged common people to adopt healthier lifestyles. Yoga is no longer limited to saints and practitioners but has become part of everyday life for students, professionals, homemakers, elderly people, and even children.

Objectives of the Study

The objectives of the present study are:

1. To study the significance of the International Day of Yoga in India.
2. To analyze the influence of yoga on the lifestyle of common people.
3. To examine the role of yoga in promoting physical and mental health.

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4. To evaluate the social and cultural impact of the International Day of Yoga.
5. To understand the importance of yoga in preventive healthcare and holistic living.

Research Methodology

The present study is descriptive and analytical in nature. The data has been collected from secondary sources such as books, research journals, newspapers, government reports, yoga publications, and authentic online resources related to yoga and wellness.

Concept of Lifestyle and Yoga

Lifestyle refers to the pattern of living adopted by individuals in their daily life, including food habits, physical activity, behaviour, social interaction, and mental attitude. In modern society, unhealthy lifestyles characterized by stress, lack of physical exercise, irregular eating habits, and mental anxiety have become common.

Yoga offers a holistic solution to these problems. It promotes discipline, balance, mindfulness, emotional stability, and physical fitness. The practice of yoga includes *Asanas* (postures), *Pranayama* (breathing techniques), meditation, and ethical principles which contribute to an improved lifestyle.

International Day of Yoga: A Global Movement

The International Day of Yoga has become an important global event promoting health and harmony. Every year, millions of people participate in yoga sessions organized in schools, colleges, parks, offices, and public spaces. In India, government departments, educational institutions, NGOs, and yoga organizations actively organize yoga programs and awareness drives.

The annual themes of International Day of Yoga emphasize global health, peace, sustainability, and human unity. The observance of Yoga Day has enhanced public awareness regarding the importance of physical activity and mental well-being.

Influence of International Day of Yoga on Common People in India

1. Promotion of Physical Health: One of the major influences of the International Day of Yoga is the growing awareness regarding physical fitness. Many people have adopted yoga practices to maintain flexibility, improve immunity, reduce obesity, and manage chronic diseases such as diabetes, hypertension, and back pain.

Regular practice of yoga helps improve posture, blood circulation, respiratory efficiency, and overall body functioning. Common yoga practices such as *Surya Namaskar*, *Tadasana*, *Bhujangasana*, and *Pranayama* are now widely practiced among Indian citizens.

2. Improvement in Mental Health: Modern life is full of stress, anxiety, depression, and emotional imbalance. Yoga and meditation help calm the mind and improve concentration, emotional stability, and inner peace. The International Day of Yoga has encouraged people to adopt meditation and breathing practices as part of their daily routine.

Students practice yoga for better concentration, professionals use yoga for stress management, and elderly people practice yoga for mental relaxation and emotional well-being.

3. Awareness of Preventive Healthcare: The celebration of Yoga Day has strengthened the idea of preventive healthcare in India. Instead of depending solely on medicines, people are becoming aware of natural methods of maintaining health through yoga, balanced diet, and disciplined living.

Yoga promotes a healthy immune system and helps prevent lifestyle-related diseases. During and after the COVID-19 pandemic, yoga gained immense popularity as people sought natural methods for improving immunity and mental resilience.

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4. Positive Impact on Daily Routine: Yoga encourages early rising, regular exercise, balanced food habits, self-discipline, and positive thinking. Many people have incorporated yoga into their daily routine after participating in Yoga Day celebrations and awareness campaigns.

The practice of yoga also reduces harmful habits such as smoking, alcohol consumption, and excessive dependence on digital devices, thereby promoting a healthier lifestyle.

5. Social Harmony and Community Participation: International Day of Yoga promotes unity, peace, and social harmony. Mass yoga events organized in public places bring together people from different religions, communities, and age groups. Yoga acts as a unifying force beyond caste, class, and regional differences.

Such collective participation develops community spirit, cooperation, and mutual understanding among citizens.

6. Revival of Indian Cultural Heritage: The global recognition of yoga has increased pride among Indians regarding their cultural heritage. International Day of Yoga has revived interest in ancient Indian knowledge systems, including Ayurveda, meditation, and holistic philosophy.

People are becoming more aware of the teachings of ancient Indian sages such as Patanjali, who systematized yoga philosophy in the *Yoga Sutras*.

Role of Educational Institutions and Media

Schools, colleges, and universities play a vital role in spreading yoga awareness among youth. Yoga competitions, demonstrations, workshops, and seminars organized during the International Day of Yoga motivate students to adopt healthy habits.

Similarly, television, newspapers, radio, and social media have contributed significantly in popularizing yoga among the masses. Online yoga sessions and digital awareness campaigns have further expanded the reach of yoga in India.

Challenges and Limitations

Despite its growing popularity, certain challenges remain:

- Commercialization of yoga has shifted focus from its spiritual and ethical dimensions.
- Lack of trained yoga instructors in rural areas limits accessibility.
- Some people still consider yoga only as physical exercise rather than a holistic lifestyle.
- Irregular practice reduces the long-term benefits of yoga.

These challenges need proper awareness, training, and policy support for effective implementation.

Suggestions

- Yoga education should be strengthened in schools and colleges.
- Government and NGOs should organize regular awareness programs in rural and urban areas.
- Qualified yoga instructors should be appointed in educational and healthcare institutions.
- Research on scientific benefits of yoga should be promoted.
- Media should emphasize the holistic and ethical aspects of yoga.

Conclusion

The International Day of Yoga has brought a remarkable transformation in the lifestyle of common people in India. It has promoted awareness regarding physical fitness, mental health, preventive healthcare, discipline, and social harmony. Yoga has emerged as an effective tool for achieving holistic well-being in modern society.

The observance of Yoga Day has also revived India's ancient cultural heritage and strengthened the global image of India as the birthplace of yoga. Although challenges such as

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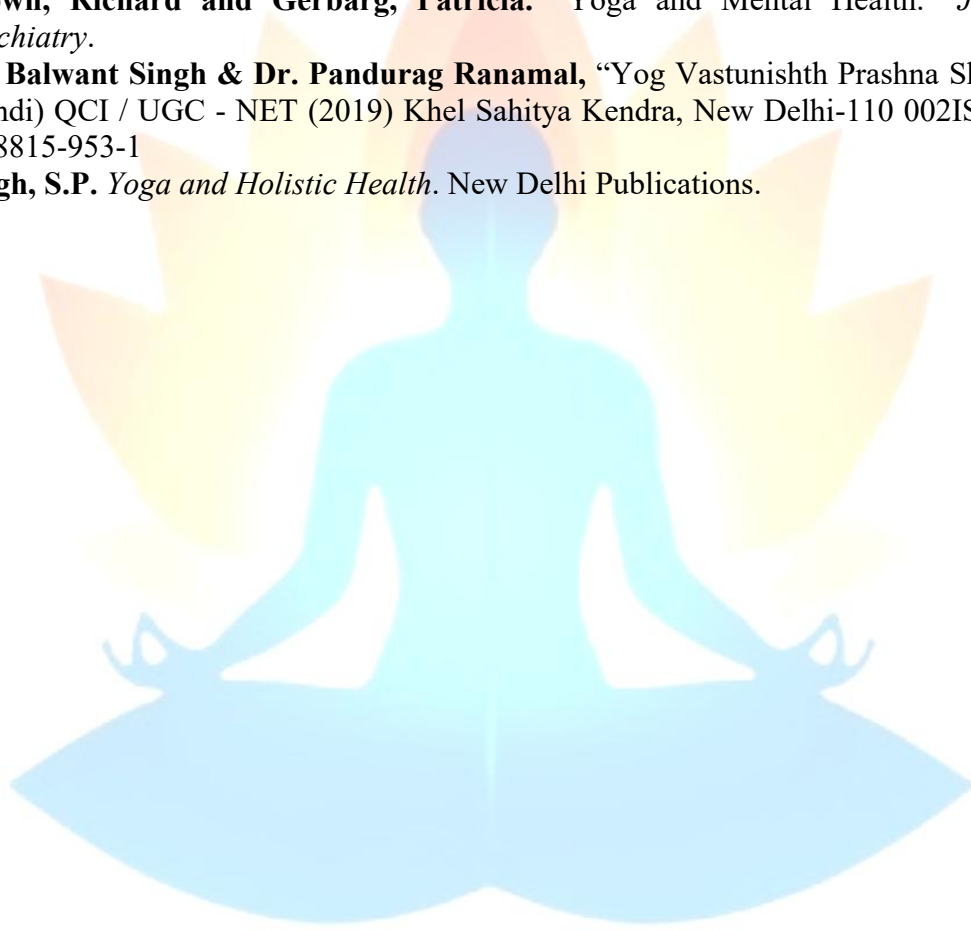
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commercialization and lack of awareness remain, the growing participation of people in yoga activities indicates a positive shift towards healthier and more balanced living.

Therefore, the International Day of Yoga is not merely a symbolic celebration but a meaningful movement contributing to the well-being of individuals and society as a whole.

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Registration No. F-00475633(THN)